

Introduction to Academic Writing

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- Interrelated skills of essay-writing and reasoning often chosen as the two most important skills for success in higher education
- Many educators feel that students most often lack essay-writing skills
- Writing ability important at work and outside world

- The purpose of this course is to cover some basic aspects of academic writing
- Heighten appreciation of the logic and beauty of language,
- Help develop a reasonable command of language which will help you to think more clearly and deeply

What is academic writing?

- Academic writing, broadly defined, is for communicating scientific knowledge.
- It is generally addressed to scholars and other knowledgeable readers who are familiar with that branch of knowledge.
- The most rigorous academic writing is found in scientific journals and doctoral dissertations in which scholars share with fellow scholars their research findings, leading to advances in knowledge in different disciplines.

- You also find less sophisticated versions of academic writing in colleges and universities. Most of the assignments that students write and submit to their instructors fall in this category.
- What is common among all classes of academic writing is that ideas take centre stage, people are in the background, and the writer's personal feelings have no role in the presentation.
- Everything that the reader needs should be explicitly stated in the text; arguments are accepted or rejected because of the logic or evidence presented there, not because of who proposes them.

- Students are required to write assignments, reports, theses, dissertations and research papers for their courses.
- They are commonly told to:
 - take up a position
 - adopt a particular perspective
 - put forward points for and against a particular position
 - explore possible positions
 - link theory and evidence
 - draw a conclusion
 - analyse
 - be critical
 - develop a central idea
 - use evidence to support an argument

How is academic writing different from other kinds of writing, say journalistic writing and creative writing?

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Journalistic writing

- The objective of journalistic writing, found in newspapers and news magazines of the print and digital varieties, is essentially to inform the readers by reporting and commenting on current events.
- It is targeted at a wide range of people who can spare very little time and yet want to know what is happening around them.
- Most journalistic writing answers, in as few and simple words as possible, the following questions: Who? What? When? Where? How? And sometimes - Why?
- Thus, journalistic writing consists of factual reporting (news reporting) and analyses of those events that show the writer's interpretation of those events.

- The preferred writing style is crisp, lively and attention-grabbing. The sentences and paragraphs are short. The content is people-centred and easy to grasp. There may be photographs and attention-grabbing personal details to support the written text.
- Successful journalistic writing attracts and keeps the casual, even non-committed reader hooked. Writers use many devices including photographs to catch the reader's eyes. Wordplay such as puns, humour and exaggeration are commonplace.
- There are norms that journalists are required to follow; those norms, however, are not as rigid as the ones academic writers have to follow.

- Here are some headlines: “Raju beats Obama on web popularity charts!” (*Indian Express*), “Nuns through YouTube” (*The Hindu*), “Wipro loses a billion on US bourses in a week” (*The Times of India*), “When Insurance Is Bad for Your Health” (*The New York Times*) and “The scent of a man” (*The Economist*).
- Once the reader is hooked in through a catchy title, nothing is allowed to hinder the flow of reading because (s)he may leave the story at any point and not come back. So good journalistic writing is lively and quick-paced.
- The people-centredness of journalistic writing leads to the generous use of verbs and the active voice. Words that appeal to the different senses are common. They help the reader participate in the event, as it were.
- Because of the wide range of readers that a newspaper reaches out to, the reporter has to build up some background information.

Creative writing

- Creative writing is expressing oneself—one's experience or imagination or a combination of both—through the written word. It creates something new.
- It is found in fiction, poetry and plays, collectively referred to as literature.
- It is the writer's subjective perception of reality that is shared with readers through words.
- But this subjectivity is acceptable to readers of literature.

- We do not ask creative writers to tell us the truth. We do not ask creative writers to provide evidence for any assumptions they make or any conclusions they arrive at. We accept what they write because what it says feels right. We reject it when we do not enjoy it. We expect creative writing to entertain us, enlighten us and transport us to aspects of life we have not experienced. We accept the content and the insights because of the way the writers take us along.
- We willingly suspend our disbelief (to borrow an expression from Samuel Taylor Coleridge) as we enter the world of fiction mediated through creative writing.
- Good creative writing displays passion, wit and intuitive knowledge. It is an art. So, one needs the basic creative talent as in music, dance or painting before it can be refined through training.

- Each creative writer has his/ her own distinctive style. One can often identify the author by examining the style of an extract. In other words, creative writing reflects the personality, attitude and values of the writer's self.
- Writers stretch and manipulate the language in different ways in the process of sharing their unusual experiences with the reader. This is often called poetic licence. There are no fixed benchmarks. Rather, a creative writer can ignore such benchmarks to create certain effects.

- Take, for example, poet e. e. cummings, who does not follow the standard rules about when to use capital letters and when to use lowercase letters.
- A creative writer can stretch and twist words to create new meanings provided (s)he takes her readers along. That is what Humpty Dumpty says in Chapter VI of Lewis Carroll's *Through the Looking Glass, and What Alice Found there*:

"When *I* use a word," Humpty Dumpty said, in a rather scornful tone, "it means just what I choose it to mean—neither more nor less."

"The question is," said Alice, "whether you *can* make words mean so many different things."

"The question is," said Humpty Dumpty, "which is to be master—that's all."

Let's look at an example...

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Version 1

- Year 2001! The performance of Indian Railways was at its worst. Revenues were stagnant and costs were escalating. A series of bad years had reduced the fund balance to only Rs 149 crores. Operating Ratio (ratio of Total Working Expenses—including depreciation and pension, but excluding dividend to GOI—to Total Earnings) was at 98.34%; and for the first time in nearly two decades, Railways had to defer the dividend payable to Government of India. The Expert Group on Indian Railways (also known as Anand Mohan Committee for Railway Restructuring) had already written the obituary of Indian Railways.

- Year 2006! Within five years of the doomsday prophecies, Indian Railways was “back with a bang”. With an operating ratio of 78.7%, it was among the most efficient railways in the world. The funds balance had ballooned to Rs 12,000 crores—and Railways was finalizing investments to the tune of Rs 350,000 crores till 2015 [Raghuram 2007]. This remarkable reversal of fortune and regaining of confidence, for a public sector enterprise, seems a story taken out of fairy-tales.

Version 2

- The performance of Indian Railways was at its worst in 2001. A series of financially bad years in which revenues were stagnant and costs rising had reduced its fund balance to Rs 149 crore. The Operating Ratio (that is, ratio of Total Working Expenses—including depreciation and pension, but excluding dividend payable to GOI—to Total Earnings) was 98.34%; and for the first time since 1983, Railways deferred the dividend payable to Government of India. The Expert Group on Indian Railways (2001), also known as Anand Mohan Committee for Railway Restructuring, concluded in the same year that this public sector enterprise was financially unviable.

In the following five years, however, there was a significant turnaround. In 2006, the operating ratio was 78.7%, among the best globally. The balance of funds rose 80 times to Rs 12,000 crore. Buoyed by this, observes Raghuram (2007), Railways decided to invest up to Rs 350,000 crore in the next ten years. This is a remarkable reversal of fortunes for a public sector enterprise.

Which of the two is academic writing?

- Compare some expressions from the first version with the corresponding expressions in the second version. “[T]he obituary of Indian Railways” has become “financially unviable.” “[B]ack with a bang” is replaced with “a significant turnaround.” The expression, “a story taken out of fairy-tales,” has been dropped.

- Academic writing is dispassionate. You may be convinced about something. You may be passionate or excited about it. But in academic writing you have to be like an impartial observer.
- You must present the pros and cons of the position you hold, rather than just evidence that supports your position. You must not suppress any inconvenient data that you cannot account for or that which blocks a neat conclusion.
- The reader may or may not agree with your position or your interpretation. That does not matter. Your credibility as an academic writer goes up when the reader finds you objective and dispassionate.
- A related feature of academic writing is that its tone is cautious and tentative rather than categorical.

- Clarity is arguably the most highly regarded virtue in academic writing.
- While creative writing is full of ambiguities and multiple layers of meanings that signal the depth, variety and complexity of the human experience, good academic writing has no room for them.

- Cleverly ambiguous expressions and puns are welcome in creative writing, and acceptable to a large extent in journalistic writing too.
- In order to achieve clarity, the academic writer may have to define the terms used, especially those terms that are loosely used in ordinary conversations.
- Another way to enhance clarity is to use pictures and charts to illustrate the point you are making, especially when you have to analyse data and compare them. If you display too many numbers one after another, your reader will be overwhelmed. Charts can present complex comparative data in a neat and easily intelligible way.

Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening

The woods are lovely, dark and deep,

But I have promises to keep,

And miles to go before I sleep,

And miles to go before I sleep.

Version 1

- Inside the intact cells of an onion, a molecule called sulfenic acid precursor floats around the watery filler *like a napping human in a lazy river*. Also floating in that cytoplasm are little sacs called vacuoles, containing a protein called alliinase, which is *like a little drill sergeant of the process*.
- “*One has not seen the other, but if you damage the cells, they can now meet and make these reactions,*” said Marcin Golczak, a biochemist at Case Western Reserve and principal investigator of the latest study. The molecule and the protein fit together *perfectly*, the chemical structure of the molecules change, and that *lazy floater becomes a smelly soldier armed with tear gas*.

Version 2

- In 1961 the Finnish biochemist Artturi Virtanen ... showed that onions contain trans-(+) S-(1-propenyl)-L-cysteine sulfoxide, a positional isomer of alliin [see bottom illustration on page 115]. That is, its chemical content is identical with that of alliin; only its structure differs. (Specifically it differs in the position of a double bond, which, as the 1 in its name indicates, is attached directly to sulfur.) Trans-(+)-S-(1-propenyl)-L-cysteine sulfoxide is the lacrimatory precursor, or LP: the onion's allinase enzyme converts it into the lacrimatory factor, or LF, the substance that makes people cry when they slice an onion.

Version 3

- Because onions are basically tiny chemical pranksters. 🧅 😄
- When you cut an onion, you break its cells. That releases enzymes that react with sulfur-containing compounds inside the onion and form a gas called **syn-propanethial-S-oxide** (yep, real name). That gas floats up into your eyes.
- Your eyes are *not* fans of mystery gases, so they go into defense mode:
- Eye nerves get irritated
- Tear glands kick in
- You cry to flush the irritant out
- So the tears aren't emotional—they're basically your eyes washing themselves.

Version 1	Version 2
Informal/ colloquial language	More formal language
Examples to help understand	No such examples
A few technical terms	A lot of technical terms
Focus on conveying the gist	Focus on extensive details
Comparisons	No such comparisons
No conventions	Academic conventions

- The first one is from *The New York Times*
<https://www.nytimes.com/2017/09/05/science/onions-crying-chemicals.html>
- The second one is from *Scientific American*, Vol 252, No, 3, 1985, pp. 114-121
<http://www.jstor.org/stable/pdf/24967598.pdf>
- The third one is a response from chatGPT

- Another most easily noticed convention is the meticulous citing of the sources of data or views borrowed from others, even when it weighs the text down and makes it less readable.
- The difference it makes is apparent if you compare an article from a scientific journal and an article from a magazine such as *Time* or *The Economist*. The journal article is likely to have a long list of references either at the end or at the bottom of each page while the magazine article may have none, even when the latter is written after considerable research. The detailed referencing we see in academic writing reflects the central characteristic of scientific inquiry, namely, focus on objectivity through reliance on empirical data rather than personal opinions or intuitions.

Citation and references

- There is a common misperception that people over a certain age (e.g., 65) tend to be less open or perhaps even averse to adopting new technologies for everyday tasks. However, more and more research makes clear that this is a misperception and an overstatement ([O'Hanlon, Bond, Knapp, and Carragher 2010](#); [Pew Internet and American Life Project 2004, 2009](#)). Many older adults use technologies widely, including personal computers and the Internet. However, little is known about the depth and breadth of technology use by older adults or whether it differs from younger adults' usage patterns.
- (<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3370300/>)

Selected References

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Selected Web Resources

- Purdue Online Writing Lab

<https://owl.english.purdue.edu/owl/>

- Massey University Course on Academic Writing

<http://owl.massey.ac.nz/main/academic-writing.php>

- How to Improve Your Academic Writing, Essex University

https://www1.essex.ac.uk/ldev/documents/study_guides/academic_writing.pdf

- Thus, academic writing is somewhat subdued like formal workplace clothes.
- It is not exuberant; it is not supposed to draw attention to itself but to the ideas conveyed through it.
- Thus, colourful expressions and bold metaphors that populate creative writing are rarely found in academic writing, especially in scholarly papers that scientific journals publish.

Key features of academic writing

- A definitive structure such as a beginning, middle, and end.
- This is typical of an essay format, as well as other assignment writing tasks.
- In an essay, the introductory paragraph informs the reader about the nature of the topic, which is discussed and evaluated in the middle of the essay, also referred to as the body. The introduction may also summarise very succinctly, in a sentence or two, your position on the issue, which is then elaborated on at length in the series of paragraphs that make up the essay's body.
- The end paragraph constitutes a conclusion in which you may summarise the overall points made, but obviously not every single one, as there is often never the word space to do so.
- The concluding paragraph is also a good point at which to move the essay forward to touch on implications or future advancements surrounding the issues addressed.

- Citation of published authors.
- If you make judgements about something in academic writing, there is an expectation that you will support your opinion by linking it to what a published author has previously written about the issue.
- Indeed, citing the work of other authors is central to academic writing because it shows you have read the literature, understood the ideas, and have integrated these issues and varying perspectives into the assignment task.
- AI use - restrictions

- Follows rules of punctuation and grammar
- The end-user or consumer of your writing, unlike a friend, is likely to be very different from you and will not always know to what you are referring. Hence, it is vital that you are clear.
- Punctuation as well as the conventions of grammar are universally known systems (within English speaking cultures) that maintain clarity and avoid ambiguity in expression.